The Class Meeting

Civic Skill: Cooperation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 5 (Communicating) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will participate in a genuine class meeting to make one real, binding decision together, experiencing the structure, frustration, and satisfaction of democratic collective decision-making.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can share my view in a group and listen while others share theirs.
- I can accept a group decision even if it's not exactly what I wanted.
- I can say how the decision was made, not just what it was.

MATERIALS

- A genuine, bounded decision for the group to make (e.g., what book to add to the reading corner; what to name the class plant; how to organise the art supplies; what to do for the last 15 minutes on Friday)
- A talking piece (any meaningful object the class has agreed signals speaking rights)
- A visible decision record (large paper on the wall)
- Picture book to follow: 'The Quiltmaker's Journey' by Jeff Brumbeau, or any story featuring a community making a collective choice

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. ISSUE INTRODUCTION (3 min): 'Today we have a real decision to make. It affects everyone here. We're going to decide together — not the teacher, not one person, all of us. Here is the decision: ___.'

2. THINKING TIME (2 min): Before anyone speaks, everyone thinks quietly. 'What do you think? Why? What's most important to you about this?'

3. SPEAKING ROUND (8 min): Each child who wishes to speak takes the talking piece and shares. One rule: while someone holds it, everyone else listens. No interrupting. Educator does not share their view — only facilitates.

4. FINDING COMMON GROUND (5 min): 'Has anyone changed their mind after listening? What did you hear that surprised you? Is there something most people agree about, even if we want slightly different things?'

5. DECISION (4 min): If consensus is possible, name it. If not, vote — and explicitly name: 'In a vote, the majority decides, but we respect everyone who voted differently. Their view was heard.' Record the decision visibly.

6. IMPLEMENT IT: The decision is enacted. This is non-negotiable. The decision must be real for the process to matter.

EXTENSIONS

- Run class meetings regularly — monthly or fortnightly — on progressively more complex issues
- Introduce a 'class constitution': the rules our class has decided together, revisited and revised periodically
- Reflect on past decisions: 'We decided ___ six weeks ago. How did it work? Would we decide the same thing again?'

ASSESSMENT

- Observation: Did the child listen while others spoke, or wait to repeat their own view?
- Key question: 'Did the group decide what you wanted? How did that feel? What helped?'
- Note children who changed their view in response to others — this is advanced civic reasoning

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How did it feel to genuinely not know what the outcome would be?
- Were there children whose voices were hard to hear in the group setting? How will you ensure they are heard next time?
- What did the process of the meeting teach children that the content of the decision could not?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 5 (Communicating). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.